



a sharp pain. The words of the charm imply that the pain comes from a woman's spear, or the invisible arrows of elves (elf-shot).

Power of objects

In common magic, seemingly mundane objects, such as stones, plants, and animals, were believed to possess power. Scholarly and religious traditions found in, for example, lapidaries (books listing the virtues of stones for magic and medicine) and bestiaries (collections of moralizing stories about animals) had also entered oral culture.

Certain plants, too, were considered to have natural powers. They were used to make magic potions or amulets, or were thought to have magical effects if gathered at certain times while saying specific words, or if placed in a particular location. For example, mugwort gathered before sunrise and placed in a person's shoe was supposed to prevent tiredness. Some magic objects were stranger. One cure for toothache, for instance, involved wearing the tooth from a dead man's skull around the neck. Rings imbued with celestial powers might be used to protect the wearer from demons or some illnesses.

Predictions

To see what the future held, people consulted men and women skilled in the arts of divination. Divining meant looking for signs and patterns in nature, for example, the way animals behaved or the flight of birds (augury), or by casting stones or bones (cleromancy). For the experts (often early cunning folk; see p.124), these were advanced arts, requiring years of study. Ordinary people often used more basic methods, such as predicting the weather using the old lore, "Red sky in the morning, shepherd's warning."



▲ The Middleham jewel

Wealthy, educated people, such as the owner of this 15th-century gold amulet, also made use of stones and charms. This amulet mixes biblical scenes and words from the Mass with magical elements, such as the word "Ananizapta," believed to be a charm against epilepsy. The blue sapphire was said to cure ailments including ulcers and headaches.

"This potent amulet, of old renowned, Wear like a bracelet on thy left arm bound."

MARBOD OF RENNES, *DE LAPIDIBUS*, 11TH CENTURY